

Growing Medicinal Plants

Growing medicinal plants may be more time-consuming than buying them, but it brings with it the unique pleasure of producing your own herbal remedies. Many medicinal herbs are easy to grow and will flourish indoors, on a windowsill, or in the garden, providing a year-round supply of fresh, sweet-smelling natural medicines.

The Medicinal Herb Garden

Planning an herb garden depends on a range of factors including the space available, exposure, soil, conditions, and climate. As a starting point, details of ten of the most common and useful medicinal plants for growing in temperate climates are given in the chart below. Some of them, such as thyme (*Thymus vulgaris*, p. 143) and sage (*Salvia officinalis*, p. 131), may be grown indoors. A number of other medicinal herbs, including German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77), lady's mantle (*Alchemilla vulgaris*, p. 163), and lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108) also grow well in a temperate climate and are well worth cultivating. If in doubt about how to care for plants or what will grow well in your garden, consult a nursery.

Outdoor Gardens

Choose a range of hardy herbs to grow in your garden that will establish themselves easily and produce plenty of foliage that can be harvested. Plant exotic or less hardy herbs in sheltered sunny sites or in containers.

Container Gardens

Many medicinal plants such as peppermint (*Mentha x piperita*, p. 114) or bay laurel (*Laurus nobilis*, p. 226) can be grown in pots,

hanging baskets, or window boxes. Care must be taken to prevent them from drying out or becoming pot-bound (when the plant becomes too large for the container). Less hardy plants should be moved to sheltered sites or indoors during winter.

Growing Plants Under Cover

Sheltered gardening offers the opportunity to grow more unusual plants. Use the greenhouse to cultivate exotic plants, such as lemon grass (*Cymbopogon citratus*, p. 198), for medicinal and culinary use, as well as for growing seedlings to be planted outdoors. Tender plants, such as holy basil (*Ocimum tenuiflorum*, p. 116), thrive indoors, and some indoor plants, such as aloe vera (*Aloe vera*, p. 60), have the added advantage of absorbing polluting chemicals from the air.

Buying Medicinal Herbs

Reputable herb nurseries are the best place to buy herbs when particular varieties or species are required. Be clear about what plants you want before visiting the nursery. When buying for medicinal use, purchase the standard medicinal, rather than an improved or ornamental variety.

Cultivation

Bear in mind the following points when planning the garden and choosing herbs.

Site

The majority of medicinal plants prefer a sunny exposure and moderately well-drained soil. It is possible to improve a site, for example by planting hedges as windbreaks. Choose sheltered, sunny corners for delicate and half-hardy herbs, and avoid planting on land formerly used for industrial purposes, which may be contaminated.

Temperature

Some plants tolerate only very specific temperature ranges, and many herbs, such as rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*, p. 128), are only half-hardy and will not survive exposure to deep or long periods of frost. Protect tender and half-hardy plants from the wind to avoid the windchill factor. Spring is the best time to plant most herbs. Wintering plants in a greenhouse or cool indoor site is often the only way to keep subtropical plants in cool temperate climates, while other herbs will thrive indoors all year round in a warm, sunny position.

Soil

Soils vary greatly depending on the proportions of sand, silt, and clay content. Sandy soils drain easily and need feeding, while clay soils can become waterlogged and require drainage.

Pruning

Pruning is used to remove dead wood and improve the shape, size, and quality of growth. It is an important garden activity and needs to be done correctly for different woody plants to benefit—check the best time of year for each plant. Deadheading plants, especially shrubs,

Useful Herbs to Grow

PLANT	WHEN TO PLANT	CULTIVATION METHOD	CONDITIONS & CARE	MEDICINAL USES
Aloe vera (<i>Aloe vera</i> , p. 60)	spring/autumn	offsets	■ sunny site indoors; pot up as needed; do not overwater	■ fresh plant gel for minor burns and wounds
Comfrey (<i>Symphytum officinale</i> , p. 138)	spring/autumn	seed/division	■ warm sunny site; moist soil	■ ointment or poultice for sprains and bruises (use the leaf only)
Feverfew (<i>Tanacetum parthenium</i> , p. 140)	autumn/spring	seed/cutting/division	■ well-drained or dry, stony soil in sun	■ fresh leaf or tincture for headaches and migraines
Lemon balm (<i>Melissa officinalis</i> , p. 113)	spring/autumn	seed/cutting/division	■ moist soil in sun; cut back after flowering	■ infusion for anxiety, poor sleep, and nervous indigestion; lotion for cold sores
Calendula (<i>Calendula officinalis</i> , p. 73)	spring/autumn	seed	■ well-drained soil; full sun; remove dead flower heads	■ cream for cuts, scrapes, inflamed skin; infusion for fungal infections
Peppermint (<i>Mentha x piperita</i> , p. 114)	spring/autumn	cutting/division	■ sunny but moist site; do not allow to dry out	■ infusion for indigestion and headaches; lotion for itchy skin
Rosemary (<i>Rosmarinus officinalis</i> , p. 128)	spring/autumn	seed/cutting	■ sunny sheltered site; protect with burlap in winter	■ infusion as a stimulating nerve tonic and to aid weak digestion
Sage (<i>Salvia officinalis</i> , p. 131)	autumn/spring	seed/cutting/layering	■ well-drained or dry, sunny, sheltered site	■ infusion for sore throats, mouth ulcers, and diarrhea
St. John's wort (<i>Hypericum perforatum</i> , p. 106)	spring/autumn	seed/division	■ well-drained to dry soil with sun or partial shade	■ tincture for depression and menopause; infused oil is antiseptic and heals wounds
Thyme (<i>Thymus vulgaris</i> , p. 143)	spring/summer	seed/cutting/division	■ well-drained soil, may need a layer of gravel; sunny site	■ infusion for coughs, colds, and chest infections; lotion for fungal infections